

scams rocking the Government," said Chennithala. The accused, however, denied having paid any money to Chennithala and said they had paid money to CPI(M) instead. "We have never known Chennithala. We have always been traditional CPI(M) supporters," said Sajith and Binish, managing directors of Himalaya.

Chennithala, too, unleashed a counter-attack against the CPI(M). He pointed out a statement of Hakeem as per which he had withdrawn all his allegations in response to a defamation notice that was sent to him in 2005. "The party has used all means to defame me. It first came out with allegations when I was leading a campaign to expose its involvement in the Rs 360-crore Lavlin scam. And now, it is trying to conceal corruption charges against a few of its workers in the *Deshabhimani* bond and LIS case," said Chennithala.

These allegations seem to have boomeranged on the CPI(M). Instead of being able to cash in on the charges against Chennithala, it is now showing signs of desperation in the face of battering from many sides. The party has been engaged in a running battle with



BLAME GAME: Youth Congress staging a protest against Balakrishnan

the media for sometime after it exposed a series of scams. The paper that has particularly invited the red wrath is *Mathrubhumi*, the second largest Malayalam daily. The party has unleashed a campaign against the paper, ignoring the fact that it is headed by M.P. Veerendra Kumar, who happens to be a top LDF leader and MP belonging to Janta Dal (S), while his son

M.V. Sreyams Kumar is an LDF legislator. Party Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan has also unleashed a vilification campaign against the paper's editor K. Gopalakrishnan. While he is busy bashing the media, Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan has conspicuously distanced himself from it. "The media should expose the evil elements in our society," he says. Amidst all these controversies, it now needs to be seen as to when the actual trial will start. ■

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